

Scaly Sanctuary GDD

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Genre: Casual, Life sim, Cute

Western (european) market

Target Platforms:

- Primary: Browser (ITCH.IO, CrazyGames), Mobile (iOS/Android)
- Secondary: Desktop (Steam, Epic, GOG)

Target audience

Casual gamers, reptile enthusiasts

Target Group: Casual gamers / animal lovers / education-focused players

Age: 13-25

Platform: Mobile & Browser

Gaming Style: Cozy, short sessions, progression-driven

Experience with Reptiles: Beginner / curious

Tech Savvy: High (mobile-first)



Profile

Lina loves cozy, low-stress games like *Stardew Valley*, *Animal Crossing*, and *Nintendogs*. She follows cute animal accounts on TikTok and YouTube and enjoys learning fun facts about animals. She's never owned a reptile, but she thinks geckos are adorable and is curious about how to care for them.

Goals

- Relax after school with a cute, low-pressure game
- Learn cool facts about reptiles without heavy reading
- Feel rewarded for helping animals
- Collect different gecko morphs

Pain Points

- Gets overwhelmed by complex systems
- Doesn't want to fail or "kill" pets
- Doesn't know anything about reptile care
- Short attention span for long instructions

What She Loves

- Cute visuals and animations
- Simple tasks (feed, clean, check-up)
- Progression and unlocking new pets
- Morphs and customization
- Friendly AI that explains things simply

Target Group: Reptile enthusiasts / experienced pet owners / gamers

Age: 18–30

Platform: Desktop + Mobile

Gaming Style: Systems-driven, progression-focused

Experience with Reptiles: Intermediate to advanced

Tech Savvy: High



Profile

Marco owns reptiles and watches reptile YouTube channels, follows Facebook groups, and reads care sheets. He has experience with snakes and geckos and got excited about morphs and breeding. He enjoys management games and sims and is curious how accurate your game is compared to real reptile care.

Goals

- See reptile care represented
- Feel like he's running a real rescue/sanctuary
- Learn niche info (breeding diet vs growth diet, enclosure setups)
- Optimize care routines

Pain Points

- Hard to find good vets in real life
- Conflicting info online

- Reptile care takes a lot of time
- Surrendering animals is emotionally tough

What He Loves

- Realistic care systems
- Different diets per species and life stage
- Accurate enclosure requirements
- Morph collection
- Breeding & growth complexity
- Educational depth

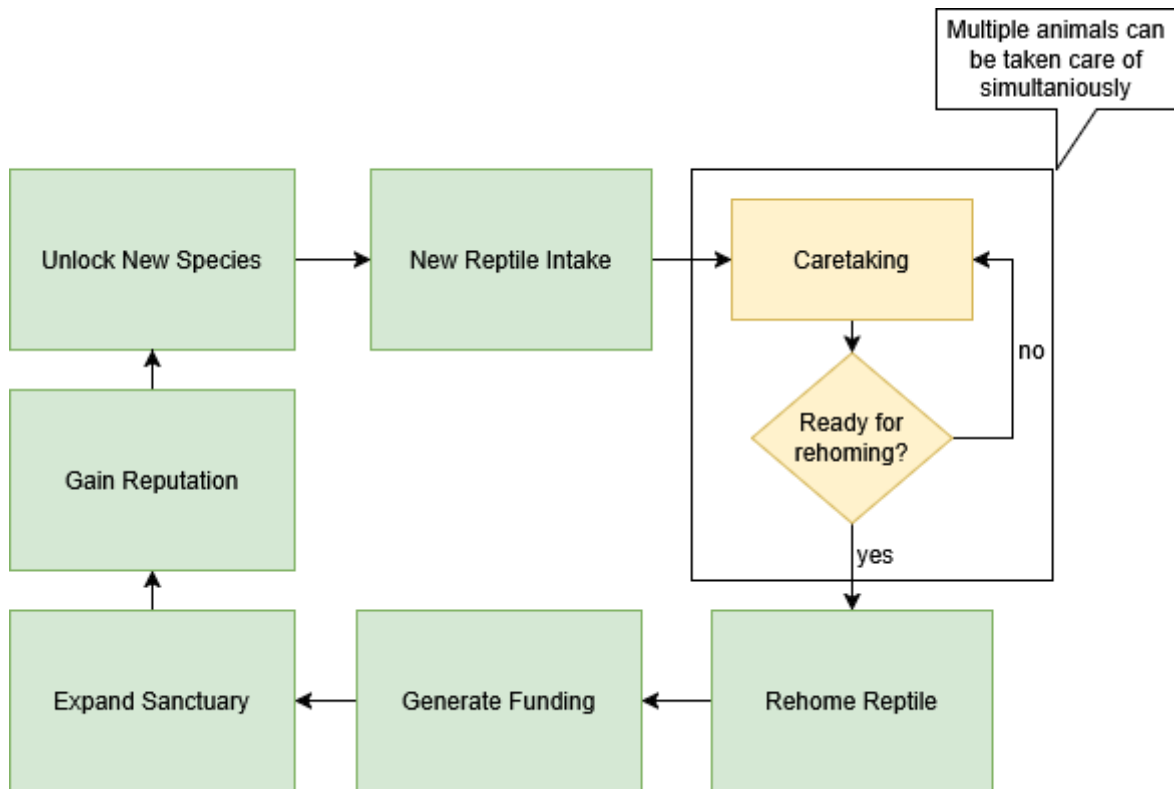
MDA framework

Aesthetics:

8 kinds of fun -> Submission

Dynamics:

- Basic caretaking
- Vet check
- Release pet
- Receive the pet



Mechanics:

Basic caretaking: Feeding, cleaning, behavior analysis

Feeding: Analyzing reptile species; choosing corresponding food; feeding in an appropriate way (dependent on reptile species and personality); analyzing feeding behavior.

Cleaning: Identify waste (shed skin, poop, mold); remove with cleaning tools (scoop, vacuum, rag).

Behavior Analysis: Looking for stillness; looking for body language; adjust humidity and temperature accordingly; heat Zones: Create basking spots (hot) and cool zones for thermoregulation; look at physical state (something in the eyes for example); clean pet accordingly.

Vet check: Taking, checking eyes, checking for stuck shed, checking mouth, chatting with AI vet (getting tips)

Rehome: Give to person

Receive the pet: Send out van, collect the pet

NURTURE - Active Caretaking

- Monitor and adjust environmental conditions (temperature, humidity, lighting)
- Feed appropriate diet based on species requirements
- Clean and maintain terrarium
- Build trust with individual reptiles through gentle interaction
- Respond to behavioral cues and health indicators

DISCOVERY - Learning Through Doing

- Unlock new species by demonstrating care proficiency
- Learn species-specific requirements through detailed care sheets
- Discover authentic reptile behaviors and ecological roles
- Uncover conservation stories for endangered/extinct species
- Experiment with habitat design and optimization

Environmental Management

- Heat Zones: Create basking spots (hot) and cool zones for thermoregulation
- Humidity Control: Adjust moisture levels via substrate, misting, water features
- Lighting Cycles: Manage UVB exposure and day/night cycles
- Substrate Selection: Choose appropriate bedding for each species
- Enrichment: Add hides, climbing structures, and decorations

Pet Care Actions

- Feed (species-appropriate diet, frequency varies)
- Provide fresh water
- Handle/pet (builds trust, species-dependent tolerance)
- Health monitoring (check stats, watch behavior)
- Veterinary care (preventive and reactive)
- Vitamin/supplement administration

Progression System

- Start with beginner-friendly species (e.g., Leopard Gecko)
- Take care for animal until it can be rehomed
- Send rescue team out to get more animals

- As you progress, more complex species come in
- Unlock terrarium upgrades, decorations, and new reptiles
- Access rare/extinct species as rare finds

Screens

The sanctuary floor. It contains terrariums for all the reptiles.



The quarantine area. It contains terrariums for new or sick animals. There is a station for the vet to inspect the new and sick animals.



The intake area. It contains the parking lot for a rescue van. It collects unwanted or found animals and brings them to the sanctuary.



Boundaries & Setting

The game takes place in Schaarhoven, a small, friendly town in the south of the Netherlands where everyone loves pets, especially reptiles. The player starts as an intern at Scaly Sanctuary, a local reptile rescue run by Emily Pip. While Emily knows a lot about reptile care, she relies on Erwin Stevens, the local vet, for medical guidance.

The game world is mostly limited to the sanctuary and the surrounding town. Certain areas of the sanctuary or town may only become accessible after completing specific tasks, learning care routines, or unlocking new equipment.

Magic Circle

Players will immerse themselves in cozy reptile care, learning to feed, clean, and interact with the reptiles, while gradually unlocking new species and terrariums.

Exploration is encouraged through:

- Visiting the town for supplies
- Discovering hidden objects or rare animals
- Interacting with NPCs to learn tips and gain rewards

The gameplay loop is low-pressure and positive: taking care of animals and completing small tasks rewards currency, items, or new animals, which encourages further care and exploration.

Feedback

Positive reinforcement: Completing care tasks or rescuing animals grants points, currency, or unlockables.

Unlockables: New species, terrarium upgrades, decorations, or minor town events.

Optional challenges: Rare reptiles or unique tasks encourage replayability and engagement without penalizing players.

Pacing

The game is designed to be relaxing and cozy, with optional moments of light challenge (new species, unique care tasks). Players can progress at their own pace, choosing which reptiles to care for and which areas of the sanctuary or town to explore. Seasonal events or town activities may provide optional variety over time.

Backstory

Scaly Sanctuary has been a beloved part of Schaarhoven for years. Emily Pip opened it with the goal of rescuing reptiles, educating the town, and providing a safe space for exotic pets. She is now looking to expand it, as Schaarhoven's population grows. The player joins as a new intern, learning the ropes while helping Emily and Erwin care for the animals. The town's love for reptiles creates a welcoming environment and a soft "suspension of disbelief" for the game's cozy and slightly whimsical world.

Danger

There is no traditional danger. "Danger" is represented through animal stress, health concerns, or containment issues. These are communicated through animations, body language, enclosure indicators, and staff comments rather than alarms or harsh warnings.

The tone remains calm and caring. Problems are framed as responsibilities, not threats.

Characters

- Player: A new intern at Scaly Sanctuary, learning to care for reptiles.
- Emily Pip / June Pip: Sanctuary owner, knowledgeable about care but relies on the vet for medical support. Friendly, approachable, and passionate about reptiles.
- Erwin Stevens: Local vet, provides medical guidance and support. Inspiring and quirky personality.
- Ted the driver: Driver for the sanctuary, picks up and delivers reptiles as needed.

- Town NPCs: Families, children, and neighbors who occasionally bring in reptiles, offer advice, or participate in events.

Victory

Victory comes in the form of rehabilitation milestones:

- An animal being ready for adoption
- A long-term resident becoming comfortable with handling
- A previously unusable enclosure being restored
- A new sanctuary wing opening

These moments serve as emotional rewards and narrative progression rather than formal “win screens.”

Artstyle

Soft shading and colored outlines, stylized and colorful

